GRAMMARFIRST · FREE SAMPLE

Swiss German Grammar Compact

30 lessons from A1 to B2 with rules, examples, tips and exercises. Answers included.



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How this workbook works

Grammar is the frame of a language. Once you understand the rules, you can build your own sentences instead of memorising phrases. This workbook walks you through the essential grammar of Swiss German step by step.

Every lesson has four parts: the **rule**, the **structure** at a glance, **examples** with translation and a **tip**. Then come five **exercises**. The answers are at the end of the workbook.

The chapters follow the levels of the Common European Framework: A1, A2 and B1. At the end of a level you have worked through its grammar once completely.

With the GrammarFirst app you can practise every lesson interactively too, with audio, spaced review and Mila the marmot.

Swiss German has no official spelling. This workbook follows what is common in Zurich. In everyday life you will see variants, for example "nöd" and "nid" or "gaa" and "gang". Both are correct.

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Free sample: lessons 1 to 3 of 30. Get the full workbook at fabio-ecosystem-ashy.vercel.app/grammarfirst/premium

Unit 1 · Erschti Schritt (first steps)

A1

1 Grüezi and Hoi

Strangers and older people are greeted with 'Grüezi', friends with 'Hoi' or 'Sali'. When leaving you say 'Uf Widerluege' or 'Tschüss'.

> **Grüezi (mitenand) · Hoi / Sali · Merci vilmal · Uf Widerluege · Tschüss / Ciao**

Situation	Hello	Goodbye
formal, one person	Grüezi	Uf Widerluege
formell, mehrere	Grüezi mitenand	Uf Widerluege mitenand
casual	Hoi / Sali	Tschüss / Ciao
Thanks	Merci / Merci vilmal	Danke vilmal

Grüezi mitenand!	Good day, everyone!
Hoi, wie gaht's?	Hi, how are you?
Merci vilmal!	Thank you very much!

Tip 'Merci' is the normal thank you. 'Danke' is understood too, but 'Merci' sounds more like Zurich.

More In Switzerland people greet strangers too, in shops, in the lift and when hiking. 'Grüezi' is for one person, 'Grüezi mitenand' for several. Among colleagues and younger people it is almost always 'Hoi' or 'Sali'. Goodbye: 'Uf Widerluege' (formal), 'Tschüss', 'Ciao' or 'Adie'.

Exercises

1. **You greet a shop assistant you don't know:**
   a) Hoi b) Grüezi c) Sali zäme
2. **Match**
   1. Merci vilmal _____ A. how are you?
   2. Uf Widerluege _____ B. hello
   3. Hoi _____ C. vielen Dank
   4. Wie gaht's? _____ D. goodbye
3. **'Grüezi mitenand' is said …**
   a) to one person b) to several people c) only in the evening
4. **Write 'How are you?' in Swiss German:** _____
5. **Translate: Fine, thanks.**

_____

2 sii: to be

The verb 'sii' (to be) is shorter than in Standard German. In the plural all persons have the same form.

> **ich bi · du bisch · er/si/es isch · mir sind · ihr sind · si sind**

Person	Zurich German	Standard German
I	bi	bin
you	bisch	bist
er / si / es	isch	ist
mir	sind	wir sind
you (pl.)	sind	ihr seid
si	sind	sie sind

Ich bi us Züri.	I am from Zurich.
Bisch müed?	Are you tired?
Mir sind dihei.	We are at home.

Tip 'mir' means 'we' here. So 'Mir sind' = 'We are'.

More 'sii' is often shortened and attached to the next word: 'Wo bisch?' instead of 'Wo bisch du?'. The pronoun is often dropped completely in questions. In the plural there is only one form for all persons: mir, ihr and si sind. This is a key pattern of Zurich German.

Exercises

1. **Du ___ nett.**
   a) bisch b) isch c) bi
2. **Mir ___ i de Stadt.**
   a) are b) isch c) simmer
3. **ich ___ (sii)** _____
4. **Translate: She is at home.**

   _____
5. **Match**

1. I	A. are
2. you	B. isch
3. he	C. bisch
4. you (pl.)	D. bi

3 de, d, s

The articles are very short: de (der), d (die), s (das). Indefinite: en (ein, m), e (eine), es (ein, n). In the plural always 'd'.

> **de Maa · d Frau · s Chind · en Maa · e Frau · es Chind · plural: d Chind**

	masculine	feminine	neuter	Plural
definite	de	d	s	d
indefinite	en	e	es	(keiner)
Example	de Hund	d Chatz	s Huus	d Hünd

S Velo isch neu.	The bicycle is new.
D Chatz schlaft.	The cat is sleeping.
Ich han en Hund.	I have a dog.

Tip Typical Zurich words: s Velo (bicycle), s Trottoir (pavement), s Rüebli (carrot).

More The feminine article 'd' merges with the word: 'd Frau' sounds almost like 'tFrau'. Before a vowel 's' is attached directly: 's Auto'. The indefinite article is 'en' (masculine), 'e' (feminine) and 'es' (neuter): en Maa, e Frau, es Chind.

Exercises

1. **___ Velo (the bicycle)**
   a) De b) D c) S
2. **___ Frau**
   a) de b) d c) s
3. **Ich ha ___ Hund. (a)**
   a) en b) e c) es
4. **Plural: ___ Chind** _____
5. **Match**

1. de	A. a (neut.)
2. d	B. the (neut.)
3. s	C. the (masc.)
4. es	D. the (fem.)



Want more?

27 more lessons with answers are waiting in the full workbook.

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